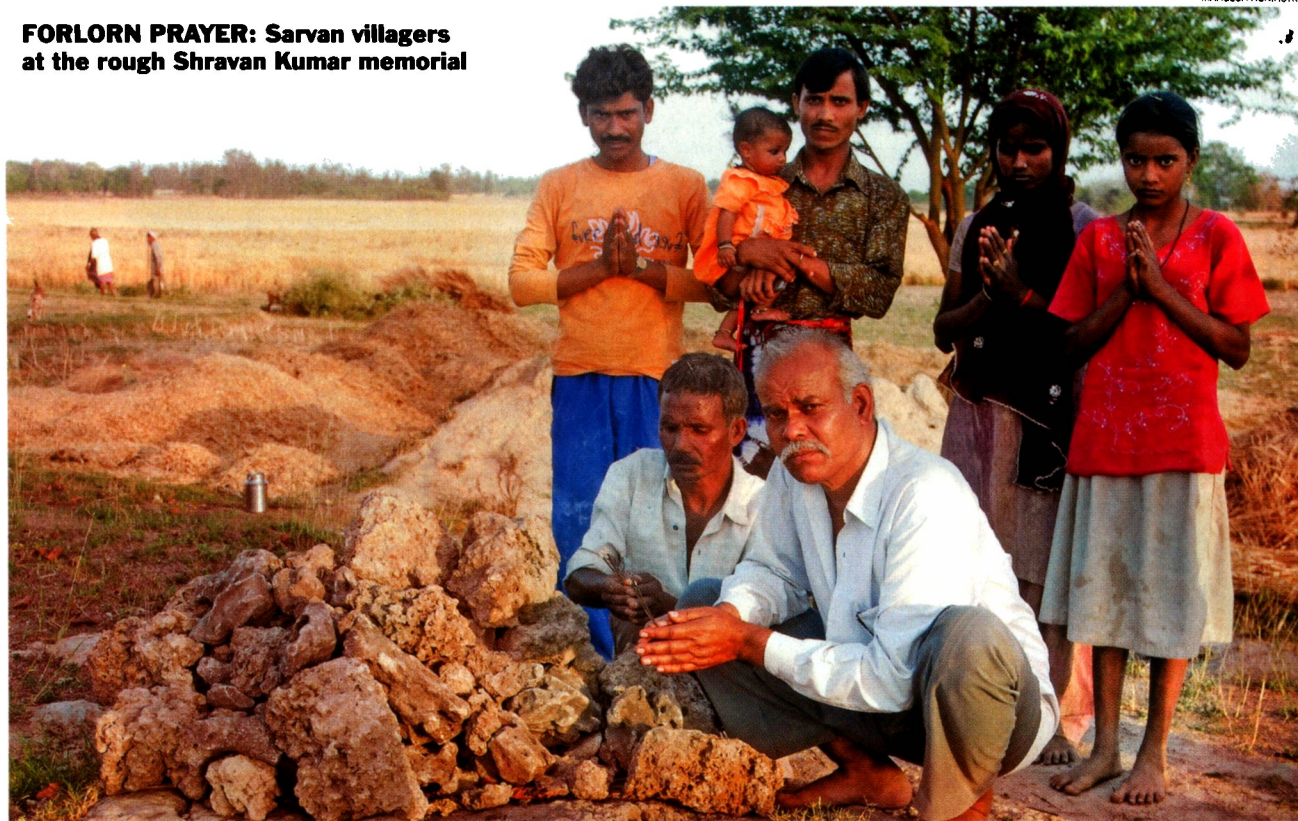


FORLORN PRAYER: Sarvan villagers at the rough Shravan Kumar memorial



An Unfinished Ancient Tale

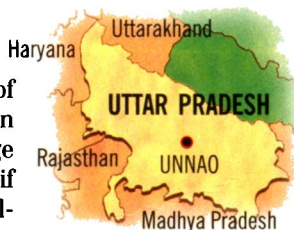
Locals of an Uttar Pradesh village believe Shravan Kumar, the Ramayan's dutiful son, died on their soil

■ **By Subhash Mishra**

One of India's most-celebrated tales of parental devotion lies buried in neglect on the banks of a parched lake in village Sarvan, Unnao district of Uttar Pradesh—if the locals are to be believed. Sarvan, claim villagers, in fact has a connection with Shravan Kumar, the character in the Ramayan, whose name has become synonymous with filial duty. Their village, they say, gets its name from Shravan Kumar as it was in fact his last resting place.

According to the legend in the Ramayan, while hunting in the forests of Ayodhya, King Dashratha heard a noise near a lake and unleashed an arrow, hoping to hit an animal. When he crossed the lake to collect his kill, he found that his arrow had struck a boy who was bleeding. The boy, Shravan Kumar, told Dashratha, that he had come to the lake to collect water for his sick and aged parents, who were both blind and who he had been carrying on a sling. He requested the king to take water to his parents. After telling his tale, Shravan succumbed to his wounds and when the king took water for his parents and told them of his tragic mistake, they were unable to bear the shock.

According to locals, the place where Shravan died was



named Sarvan. The spot where Dashratha shot his arrow came to be known as Sarwara and the place where Shravan's parents died is called Samadha.

An old and rough memorial for Shravan on the banks of the lake is now withering away. According to Munnu Lal Pandey, a former pradhan of Sarvan, the 19th century *British Gazetteer* states: "It is said that there lies a stone statue of Shravan Kumar and as he died of unquenched thirst, if water is poured into the navel of the stone figure, the hole never gets filled up."

Villagers from Sarvan and adjoining places visit the spot every Monday to offer prayers to Shravan, who is revered as a dutiful son. "Unfortunately the state government has chosen to ignore him," says Pandey. Visitors have to criss-cross a muddy road along a canal and in rains the area becomes inaccessible because of water logging.

Hridaya Narain Dixit, former Uttar Pradesh minister of parliamentary affairs says the neglect of the area reflects the couldn't-care-less attitude of the Central and state governments towards local lore. The residents of Sarvan feel the Shravan memorial should be renovated and be declared a tourist spot. They continue to nurture hope that it will be restored and given its rightful due.